A Glossary of Islamic Terms

Plain-language definitions for new readers

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How to use this glossary

This booklet defines common terms that appear throughout Islamic books. The definitions are brief and descriptive, written for readers encountering them for the first time.

Acts of worship

Salah — the ritual prayer performed five times daily. **Sawm** — fasting, especially during the month of Ramadan. **Zakat** — obligatory charity calculated on qualifying wealth. **Hajj** — the pilgrimage to Mecca, obligatory once in a lifetime for those who are able. **Dhikr** — remembrance of God, often through short phrases of praise. **Du'a** — personal supplication or prayer.

Qur'an and its sciences

Qur'an — the holy book of Islam, regarded by Muslims as the word of God revealed to the Prophet Muhammad. **Surah** — a chapter of the Qur'an; there are 114. **Ayah** — a verse of the Qur'an. **Tafsir** — scholarly commentary explaining the Qur'an. **Tajwid** — the rules governing the correct recitation of the Qur'an. **Juz'** — one of thirty roughly equal parts into which the Qur'an is divided for recitation over a month.

Hadith and law

Hadith — a report of the Prophet's sayings, actions, or approvals. **Sunnah** — the Prophet's established practice and way of life. **Isnad** — the chain of transmitters of a hadith. **Sahih** — 'sound'; a classification for rigorously authenticated reports. **Hasan** — 'good'; a sound classification slightly below sahih. **Da'if** — 'weak'; a report whose chain does not meet the strongest standards. **Fiqh** — Islamic jurisprudence, the understanding of practical law. **Ijma'** — scholarly consensus. **Qiyas** — analogical reasoning in law.

Community and culture

Ummah — the global Muslim community. **Masjid** — a mosque, a place of prostration and prayer. **Imam** — a prayer leader, or a leading scholar. **Mu'adhdhin** — the person who calls the adhan, the call to prayer. **Madrassa** — a school, traditionally one teaching religious and sometimes general sciences. **Ulama** — the collective body of Islamic scholars.

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